

But Isn’t SQL Dirty?

Ever since developers first wrapped relational databases with an object-oriented layer, they’ve debated the question of how deep to run the abstraction. Some object-relational mappers seek to eliminate the use of SQL entirely, hoping for object-oriented purity by forcing all queries through an OO layer.

Active Record does not. It was built on the notion that SQL is neither dirty nor bad, just verbose in the trivial cases. The focus is on removing the need to deal with the verbosity in those trivial cases (writing a ten-attribute `insert` by hand will leave any programmer tired) but keeping the expressiveness around for the hard queries—the type SQL was created to deal with elegantly.

Therefore, you shouldn’t feel guilty when you use `find_by_sql` to handle either performance bottlenecks or hard queries. Start out using the object-oriented interface for productivity and pleasure and then dip beneath the surface for a close-to-the-metal experience when you need to do so.

In the old days of Rails, people frequently resorted to using `find_by_sql`. Since then, all the options added to the basic `find` method mean you can avoid resorting to this low-level method.

Reloading Data

In an application where the database is potentially being accessed by multiple processes (or by multiple applications), there’s always the possibility that a fetched model object has become stale—someone may have written a more recent copy to the database.

To some extent, this issue is addressed by transactional support (which we describe in *Transactions*). However, there’ll still be times where you need to refresh a model object manually. Active Record makes this possible with one line of code—call its `reload` method, and the object’s attributes will be refreshed from the database:

```
stock = Market.find_by(ticker: "RUBY")
loop do
  puts "Price = #{stock.price}"
  sleep 60
  stock.reload
end
```